Source: Facebook Posts by BJP UP, Vasundhara Raje, Shivraj Singh Chouhan and BJP Arunachal Pradesh (2017–2019), curated through the Narad Index

This strategic adaptability was not without its challenges. When Amit Shah visited Mizoram in 2014, one of the questions the BJP's state unit leaders put to him was about a possible nationwide beef ban. At a time when beef politics and the BJP's support for an end to 'illegal' cow slaughter was becoming a major issue in the northern states, Mizoram BJP President J.V. Hluna told reporters that he had asked the party's national president how a beef ban was possible in the state. According to him, Shah responded by asking, 'if the Bible allows you to eat [beef]'.[53] Hluna said that Shah assured him that 'there is nothing to worry and asked us to follow our tradition. And, as per Bible and our tradition, consumption [of] beef is allowed.'[54] However, when the Central government approved a new rule banning the sale of cattle for slaughter nationwide—the Regulation of Livestock Markets Rules, 2017, under the Prevention of Cruelties to Animal Act, 1960—beef and cow politics emerged as a major issue in the Northeast. This caused BJP leaders in virtually every north-eastern state to declare that there would be no end to beef-eating and that the BJP did not intend to dictate food habits in the region. As Manipur Chief Minister Biren Singh told a newspaper: 'Beef is very important here. All Christians eat it, most tribal communities, valley people eat beef. It is part of traditional diet now. Even the younger generation has taken to it now. The BJP is only trying to regulate the beef industry to avoid illegal slaughter for hygiene purposes.' He categorically assured voters that the party 'will not violate people's right to eat what they have been traditionally eating for many years'.[55]

Within a week, the issue flared up again in Meghalaya, where there was a controversy around BJP district-level office-bearers announcing a proposed beef-bitchi (a local drink) party to celebrate three years of the Modi government. The party's North Garo Hills District President Bachu C. Marak posted an invitation to the proposed beef party on Facebook, earning a rebuke from the BJP's Meghalaya in-charge Nalin Kohli. The West Garo Hills President, Bernard Marak, quit over the issue, although a central BJP leader